



this: "India is guilty of exporting terror to Balochistan and other areas of Pakistan. New Delhi and Islamabad should not be distracted by such incidental fireworks as 26/11 and keep the conversation going. That is the only way forward, though we have no idea about the destination. Pakistan may continue to shelter the jihadists who have declared war on India but so what? We have other things to talk about, like the weather. Manmohan is ready to put everything—including the old darned disputes like Kashmir—on the table." Now India and Pakistan are equals in their sins, and it took the sagacity of a Mahatma Manmohan to tell the truth. Or is it Dr Singh's deal that is as good as Dr Faustus'? To counter the growing impression that the nation has been sold cheap at Sharm el-Sheikh, the foreign secretary has come out with another only-in-India gem. He says, with a straight face, that India has

not compromised, that it was all a case of bad drafting. Imagine a top Foggy Bottom official attributing a contentious statement from Obama to the President's bad semantics.

The terrible truth is that the entire history of UPA Government's Pakistan policy is a badly drafted narrative with a missing theme: national interest. New Delhi has consistently failed to acknowledge Pakistan for what it really is: the unofficial headquarters of jihad. There has hardly been a post-9/11 terror attack without a Pakistani link; it's where the sanguineous rage of radical Islamism is ensured institutional protection. Mumbai was the most explicit reminder that India is its most bloodied victim. We can take a lot more, we the stoic nation with its legendary sang froid: bombs may explode in its busy marketplaces and cadavers may multiply, but our ruling political class will overcome the day with platitudinous bunkum. They have elections to win, communities to appease, so they will take refuge in such inanities like terror-has-no-religion. Terror has geography too, and the prime minister and the mandarins of South Block can't pretend to be unaware. So, if a nation's foreign policy is an extension of its domestic policy, the prime ministerial prostration in Sharm el-Sheikh or allowing Washington to be the last arbiter of our nuclear independence should not be all that surprising.

Is forsaking the nation the only way to win a character certificate at international high tables? If the prime minister and his tutors in international affairs cared to look around at dinner tables in places as interesting as L'Aquila, they would certainly have learnt a few lessons on why national interest is a constant in the dealings of some of the most internationally visible leaders of the day, no matter whether they are from Washington or Paris or Beijing. Today Manmohan Singh is a much indulged item—soft, moderate, reasonably scholarly and endearingly exotic—at some of the high profile datelines of international diplomacy. That is essentially a tribute to India—the only stable democracy in south Asia and an opening marketplace with untapped potential. Well, the leader of India is worth indulging, and our prime minister is enjoying every bit of it. And fair enough; after all, where else can he get such undistracted, singular attention? Not in the New Delhi of the-Church (10 Janpath)-and-the-State (7 Race Course Road) hierarchy. Still, the prime minister should know: the mark of a true statesman is that he is never defensive about his nation, even if he is jetlagged. ■